

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

GLASSHOUSE

WOMEN *AT HOME*

This Republic Day, the At Home event at Rashtrapati Bhavan was a showcase of southern charm. President **Droupadi Murmu** and her secretary, IAS officer **Deepti Umashankar**, assisted by a core team, ensured that the evening seamlessly combined creativity and finesse. The invitation itself was a keepsake: a pencil pouch in Pochampally ikat (Telangana), Etikoppaka toys (Andhra Pradesh), a Ganjifa fridge magnet (Karnataka), a Kancheepuram silk pouch (Tamil Nadu) and a screw-pine woven bookmark (Kerala), all nestled in a bamboo box with Kalamkari motifs. The distinguished invitees, including the 'drone didis' and natural farming pioneers, were welcomed by couples from the southern states in traditional attire. The cuisine was south Indian but with innovative twists. From the decor to the dishes, this At Home was an ode to women's ability to blend tradition, innovation and flair.

KERALA CEASEFIRE

State governor **Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar** seems intent on patching up with the Left Front government, the same that was engaged in a bitter battle with his predecessor, Arif Mohammed Khan. On January 23, Arlekar visited V.S. Achuthanandan, the 101-year-old Communist veteran and ex-CM. "I regard him as someone who led an exemplary public life," Arlekar told the media later, adding that he has been a fan since his student days. In his R-Day speech, the guv spoke of "working together", even praising CM Pinarayi Vijayan's development vision. But it's not all sweetness and light, sources in both camps say they are in wait-and-watch mode to see if the peace holds.



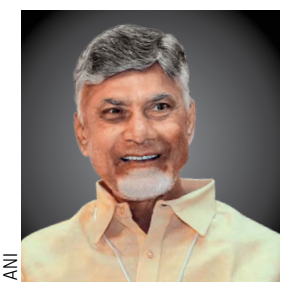
A Door to the Future

Former Union minister and BJP leader **John Barla** was at a public event in Alipurduar when he got tongues wagging by cosying up to West Bengal CM and Trinamool Congress boss **Mamata Banerjee**. Barla insists he was merely honouring a "cordial invite" from the state government, but then came the plot twist—he took a swipe at his own party, lamenting his lack of freedom in the BJP. "Look at the CM—she's been here for days... she's done so much," he said, practically fawning over "the guardian of Bengal". Asked whether he was jumping ship, Barla played coy, leaving the door open for "the future".





SWISS AUDIT

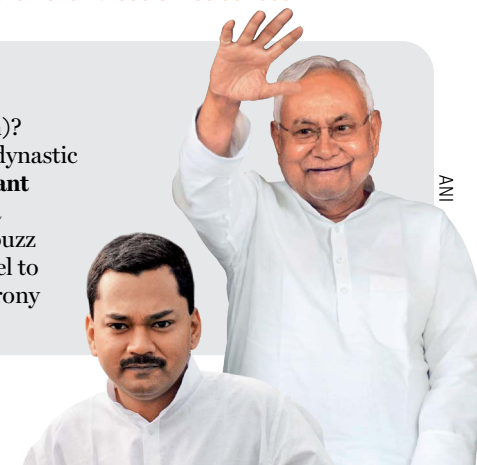


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It was that time of the year again when chief ministers of all hues were jetting off to Davos and the World Economic Forum to reel in investments. Among this year's attendees were **N. Chandrababu Naidu** (Andhra Pradesh), Devendra Fadnavis (Maharashtra) and A. Revanth Reddy (Telangana), but it was the latter who scored bragging rights after snagging pledges for Rs 1.78 lakh crore in investments. Naidu, a former Davos regular, threw some serious shade into proceedings, calling the MoU frenzy pointless, and insisting the WEF is all about networking and tuning into global trends. Maybe it's time we audited the RoI on these Swiss soirees.

A Late Winter Son Rise

Is Bihar's anti-dynasty crusader finally succumbing to *parivarvaad* (nepotism)? Rumours are rife that Chief Minister **Nitish Kumar**, 73, a long-time critic of dynastic politics, might be warming up to the idea of keeping it in the family. Enter **Nishant Kumar**, his 48-year-old famously low-profile son, who could be gearing up for a political curtain call just in time for the 2025 assembly polls. Party circles are abuzz with talk of Nishant's debut, with the engineer-turned-reluctant-heir adding fuel to the fire with a public appeal on January 8, urging voters to back dear old Dad. Irony much? Bihar's anti-dynasty poster-boy might well be crowning a new prince.



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Kaushik Deka with Jeemon Jacob, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava and Amarnath K. Menon